

my reading of content is determined more by the content itself and who wrote it, rather than who published it. For routine news, the source may not matter. I may reconfirm surprising news by checking on multiple sources. For opinion articles, I am more likely to be influenced by the person who is writing rather than the paper. Subscribing to numerous news outlets is not an acceptable or realistic option.

We may want to or may even be forced to pay for news, like the charges for radio we paid many years ago. The trouble is, whom to pay and how much. Donations work to an extent, but they probably benefit only the well known sites like Wikipedia or WikiLeaks.

The following is more a wish for what seems plausible.

A part of the ISP's charges could be used for paying the content providers who do not carry ads. An option could be that, upon reading an article, a user could click on the *Pay* button. The users' contributions could be distributed among the content providers they choose to pay.

As individuals, we are helpless in avoiding giving data to advertisers. So, if I consider all the above scenarios, I believe that a major factor in our relying on 'free' sites has

been because the ISPs just did not live up to expectations — either by not offering us options or like AOL or trying to restrict what we can do.

Internet based applications have been developing very rapidly. But there is still time to take control of our lives online. If we do not wish all our data to be owned by just a few companies, mostly in the US, our ISPs and regulators need to take the initiative and create an environment in which competition grows. It matters little if you can choose between ISPs, if the data destination options remain the same few. In the long run, it is just too risky to trust and rely on even well-meaning corporates and governments. What will they do with your data when their income levels drop to less than they expected? 

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The author has earned the right to do what interests him. You can find him online at <http://sethanil.com>, <http://sethanil.blogspot.com>, and reach him via email at anil@sethanil.com.

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